



# **HopHacks 2026 Hacker Guide**



# Communication

**Discord:** [<https://discord.com/invite/CgQWn2saP9>]

- Everything has a channel, so post in the right one for the fastest response!
- During the hackathon, please go to HQ (Hodson 211) if you want to ask in-person instead.

## General Questions:

- For general questions before the hackathon, please email us at [hophacks@gmail.com](mailto:hophacks@gmail.com)
- In an emergency, please contact one of the organizers and see here for the appropriate number:
  - [Emergency Contact Information | Johns Hopkins University](#) (use Homewood Campus)

# Check-In

## When and Where

- Check in at the Glass Pavilion (Levering Hall, 3400 N Charles St Glass Pavilion, Baltimore, MD 21218) anytime between 6-8 PM on Friday, September 18.
- There is no storage area. It is recommended to keep your belongings with you at all times.

## What to Bring

- **Student ID and a government-issued ID.**
- We will turn away anyone who is not currently enrolled in a university. High school students are not eligible to participate.

## Early Arrival:

- Feel free to check at the Glass Pavilion (Levering Hall, 3400 N Charles St Glass Pavilion, Baltimore, MD 21218). If we're not finished setting up, we'll redirect you to go explore campus.

## Late Arrival:

- If you are planning on arriving any later than 8 PM on September 18th, please send us an email with your name (and teammates' names if applicable). Check-in at HQ (Hodson 211) upon arrival.
- Please do not abuse this, especially if you live nearby/can show up on time reasonably. This is only for people with extenuating travel circumstances.

## IMPORTANT:

**Do not remove your wristband after check-in. You cannot regain access to the building if you do.  
Check-in is first come, first served. Arrive early to secure your spot.**

## Location and Rooms

### Glass Pavilion

Johns Hopkins University, Levering Hall, 3400 N Charles St Glass Pavilion, Baltimore, MD 21218

View the campus map [here](#), but our organizers will be around to guide you!

See the room breakdown below:

| Name          | Room                                          | Purpose                     |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Hacking Space | Hodson 213, 216, 301, 303, 311, 313, 315, 316 | Hackers home                |
| HQ            | Hodson 211                                    | Organizers home             |
| Sponsors Hall | Great Hall, Glass Pavilion                    | Sponsors home               |
| Workshop Room | Hodson 210                                    | All sponsor workshops       |
| Food Hall     | Glass Pavilion, Levering Hall                 | Opening ceremony + all food |
| Auditorium    | Hodson 100                                    | Closing ceremony            |
| Sleep Room    | Hodson 203 (Women's), Hodson 210              | Sleeping room opens 11 PM   |
| Showers       | Maryland Hall Basement                        | Showers close at 9 PM       |

## Tracks

**Our full list of tracks, descriptions, and prizes will be announced at our Opening Ceremony!**

Everyone is eligible for Best Overall Hack (1st, 2nd, and 3rd).

This year's sponsor tracks are:

- **Gaming**
- **Memetics**
- **Philanthropy**
- **Data**
- **Healthcare**

*You can only submit to ONE track, so choose wisely!*

For our branded prizes, you can opt-in if you meet the requirements.

- If you don't meet the requirements, don't sweat it. If you do, take your chances at winning!

Sponsors are responsible for distributing their own prizes, so they will reach out to you after the hackathon about how to collect your prize, if not sooner.

The only prize HopHacks will be in-contact with you regarding is for the Best Overall Hack.

## Schedule and Workshops

See our website for the main event schedule (which we will continuously update). All workshops are taking place in Hodson 210, except the pre hackathon event at the PAVA Center for Entrepreneurship.

## Hacking Resources

### Mentors

Mentors from our sponsoring companies are available to help if you get stuck, so don't hesitate to ask. Some sponsor tracks have preferred platforms and tools, so visit the Sponsors Hall and talk to them. Many have hackathon experience and are happy to help.

### Organizers

Our organizers are pretty knowledgeable too!

### MLH Hardware Lab

MLH is bringing their hardware lab! Check out the details here: <https://hack.mlh.io/hardware>

## Submissions

**Devpost for submissions:** [<https://hophacks-fall-2026.devpost.com/>]

Your GitHub repo must be created no earlier than 9:00 PM on Friday, September 18th.

You must submit to Devpost no later than 9:00 AM on Sunday, September 20th.

You are allowed to use any AI tools you want, but your work must be your own (i.e. you prompted). Also, you must be able to explain all the code in your repo.

**All submissions are checked for plagiarism. Hacks found to violate the rules will be disqualified automatically, without notification. Do not copy from other repos.**

# Judging

## Science Fair

Judging will take place across rooms in Hodson Hall from 10 AM to 12 PM on Sunday, September 20th. You will have several rounds of judging for ~10 minutes each. This is for determining track prizes and branded prizes, and a first screening for Best Overall Hack.

## Instructions

A random table number will be assigned to your team. This will be announced in Discord.

Do not panic about the number of judges who visit your table. The number depends on which track/prizes you submitted to. You should expect at least three rounds of judging (two for Best Overall Hack and one for the sponsor track).

They may also take some time to get to you, so please be patient!

## Criteria

- Utility
- Polish
- Creativity
- Difficulty

## Top 10 Demos

The Top 10 teams will give a 5-minute pitch between 1:00 PM to 2:00 PM to determine the winners for Best Overall Hack. Timing will be very strict, so prepare wisely.

If you didn't get selected, come support your friends and other hackers anyways!

## Food

We will be providing 6 free meals, in addition to Red Bull for caffeine.

For snacks and drinks, we will be handing them out at mealtime. Please only take what you need, and be mindful of other hackers.

Snack drop schedule? Announcements will be made in Discord as well.

## Sleep and Hygiene

It is a hackathon... sleeping is not recommended (we have infinite caffeine for you)

### **But if you must:**

The Sleeping Room opens at 11 PM each night. Bring a sleeping bag, mask, etc.

Pro tip: if you're optimizing for luggage, pillow >>> sleeping bag

You are also more than welcome to book a hotel or Airbnb, but that would be at your own expense.

### **Showers**

Located in the Maryland Hall basement. It closes at 9 PM each night. Ask an organizer to take you.

### **Restrooms**

There are plenty of restrooms in the Hodson Hall, but please clean up after yourself.

# Travel and Parking

If you still haven't booked travel... do it ASAP.

## Local train station: BAL

<https://www.amtrak.com/stations/bal>

## Local airport: BWI

<https://bwiairport.com/>

- You can also fly to DCA, IAD, etc. but that may require a longer Uber/Lyft after.

## Recommendations

- NY: Amtrak (there is also Greyhound/Peter Pan)
- DC: Amtrak/Marc

## Lodging

We do not offer any discounts or rates, but here are a few local suggestions if your team is looking for lodging near our campus.

- [The Inn at the Colonnade Baltimore](#) (trusted but slightly further)
- [The Study at Johns Hopkins](#) (closer but slightly more expensive)

## Parking

Parking is available in the South Garage, located under Mason Hall. The entrance is on Wyman Park Drive. We'll only provide vouchers for exit on Sunday, September 20th (to be picked up at Organizer HQ at Hodson 211).

# Thank you

We are so grateful to have you attending HopHacks, and we hope you have an amazing time! Our organizers, advisors, sponsors, mentors, volunteers, and more, have all put a lot of time into making this an incredible experience for everyone!